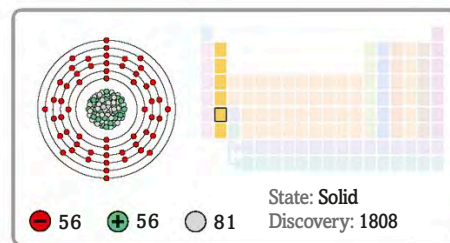


56

Ba

Barium



Forms

This mineral is used to make ceramic glazes.

Witherite



Farmers used witherite as **rat poison** until the 18th century.

This soft metal has a light, golden shine.



A grey layer of tarnish forms when the metal comes into contact with air.

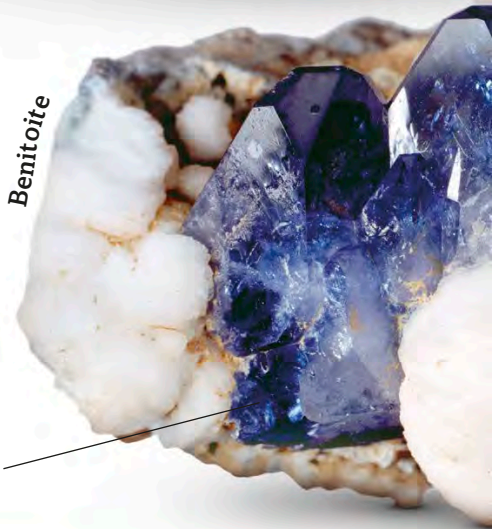
Desert rose

Petal-like shapes form in the desert when sand mixes with barite or with gypsum.



Benitoite

These glassy, blue crystals contain barium and titanium.



Barium is named after the Greek word *barys*, which means “heavy”, because **barium** and its minerals are dense. The **pure form** of this element was first discovered in 1808 by the English chemist Humphry Davy, who extracted it from an oxide of barium. This

does not exist in nature. Davy obtained it by heating the mineral **witherite**. Today, the main source of barium is barite, a mineral of sulfur that forms in deserts and in rock deposits that come into contact with hot water. A rarer mineral called **benitoite** also contains barium. The